

8.4 Bringing it all together – storytelling and presentation design ↕

Storytelling is an age-old practice that is used to impart information in a memorable way. Common traits exist among memorable stories. A good story will draw and hold the audience's attention. It is also likely to improve the recall of the information and the insights that are imparted in the process of telling the story.

Aristotle's rhetorical triangle

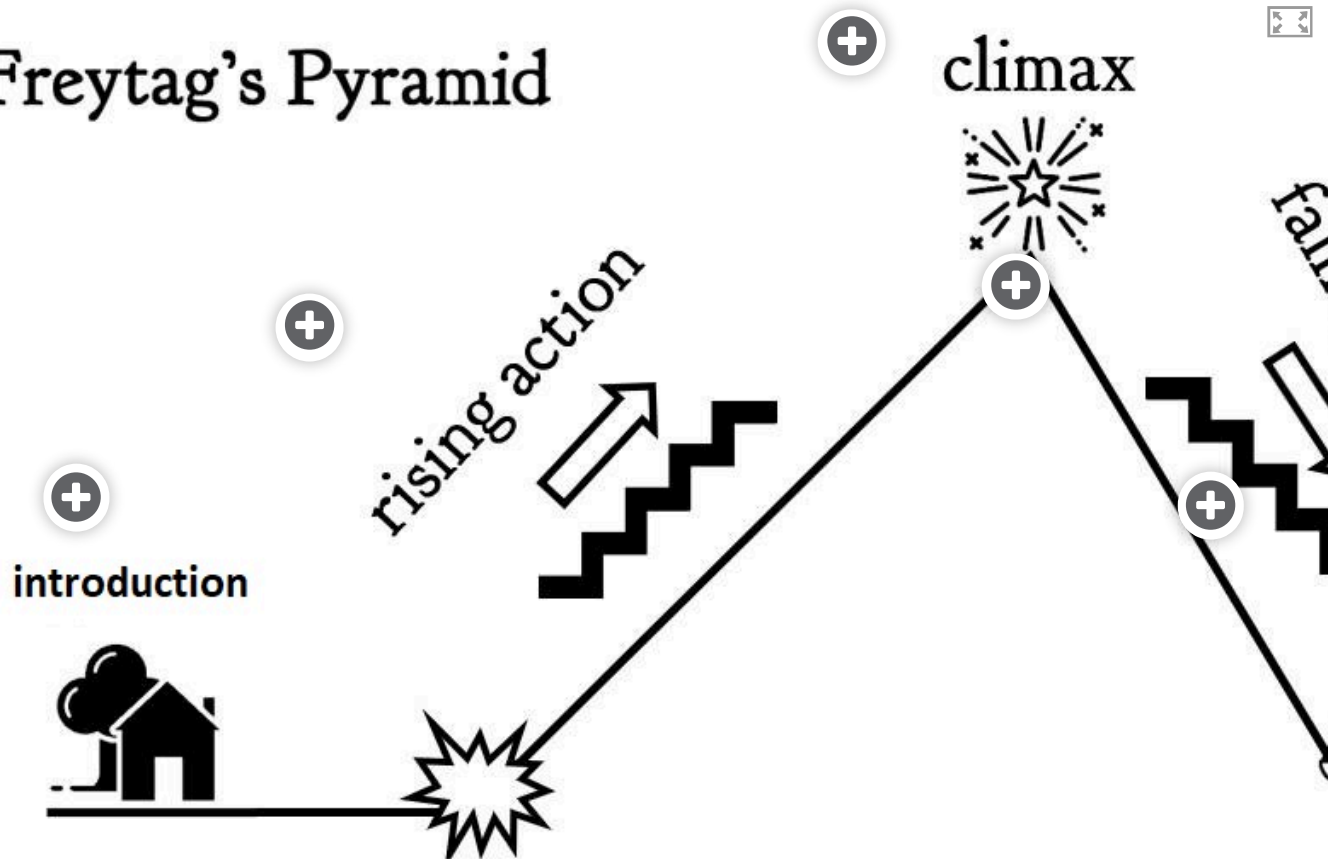
Greek philosopher Aristotle noticed that stories often share similar characteristics. Recognising that in storytelling it is important to be able to connect with an audience, Aristotle proposed three areas in which a story should connect with an audience. These three areas are visualised in what is commonly known now as the *rhetorical triangle*. They are *ethos*, *pathos* and *logos*.

- Ethos refers to the ability to show credibility in a story, which means that the audience must trust that the data is being presented truthfully. In terms of data visualisations or presentations, this requires that the data used is accurate and that insights from the data are not distorted or hidden. It is important to be open about the origin of the data and any assumptions that have been made, and by disclosing any data manipulation. Presenting alternate interpretations may also be useful.
- Pathos refers to using emotion to connect with the audience. Supporting the audience to generate empathy with the data is important. Focussing on specific instances rather than general situations may assist with this. (See above section on “Empathising with data”.)
- Logos refers to the reasoning in the story/presentation. It is important to present a clear, logical argument on how the data and analysis led to the insights being emphasised, and how the insights will help better decisions to be made.

Freytag's pyramid

Freytag's pyramid divides a story into five parts. Click on the + icons in the image below to see the details:

Freytag's Pyramid



Many well-known literary works and films follow this structure.

A carefully constructed persona can help bring the story to life and engender empathy for those involved and hence the (real) data and insights that are presented within the story. It is important to have the data-driven analysis woven through the narrative.

Storyboarding

A storyboard provides a visual representation of the main points of a story. They provide structure for the narrative of a story and therefore can be used as a simple scaffolding tool in the story development process. They help to organise thoughts and, being “modular”, they allow for story sections to be reordered as considered appropriate. This allows for the most effective story to be developed. Two differing methods commonly used are:

1. *low-tech using sticky Post-It notes*. This is a “pencil and paper” method using easy to manipulate sticky notes which can be added, reordered or removed with ease. This method encourages the story designer to be methodical and ordered, and not jump ahead to the final slides of a presentation (at an early stage in the development process).
2. *higher-tech using presentation software (e.g. MS PowerPoint)*. If this method is chosen, it is important that the storyboard designer concentrates on developing the slides in line with the stages of the story (see Freytag's pyramid above). The process of developing the storyboard should be separate to the process of developing the final presentation. The slide sorter view,

available in software (such as MS PowerPoint), is useful for manipulating (moving and deleting) the order of the stages of the story and provides an overall view of the story.

□ Watch: PowerPoint storytelling [8.14 mins]

This video provides further reinforcement of the benefits of storytelling when creating presentations. It introduces the SCQA framework (Situation, Complication, Question, Answer) and the pyramid principle, and demonstrates that compelling insights and an engaging narrative can enable an audience to clearly understand a takeaway message.

As you watch, consider:

- How does the structure of a story make a difference to the way audiences react to the message in the story?
- Why does conveying data insights in a carefully structured manner so powerful?



Source: © Analyst Academy (2021).